

Echo & Chronicle

History They Didn't Teach You

The Deeper File: Alger Hiss

Exclusive to Echo & Chronicle Subscribers

The article told you the story of the trial. What it couldn't fit was everything that came after. And everything that was buried underneath.

Because the Alger Hiss case did not end in 1950 when the jury came back with a verdict. It did not end in 1954 when he walked out of Lewisburg Federal Prison. It did not end in 1996 when he died at 92, still insisting he had been framed. In some ways it has not ended yet.

What follows is the part of the story that most people never get to. The hidden program that ran for decades inside a girls' school in Virginia. The pumpkin that was not quite what it seemed. The typewriter that may or may not have been real. The Soviet general who said one thing and then took it back. And the decoded cables that finally, after fifty years, appeared to settle the question. Or did they.

Pull up a chair. This one goes deep.

The Secret Program Nobody Knew About

While Alger Hiss was sitting in a federal courtroom in 1949, another story was unfolding in the background that nobody in that courtroom knew anything about. Not the judge, not the jury, not even most of the prosecutors.

In a converted girls' school in Arlington, Virginia, a small team of U.S. Army cryptanalysts had been quietly working for years on one of the most sensitive intelligence operations in American history. Their assignment was to break Soviet codes. The program had a randomly assigned name with no meaning attached to it: Venona.

It had started in 1943, when a signals intelligence officer worried that the Soviets might be secretly negotiating a separate peace with Germany ordered his team to begin intercepting and decrypting Soviet diplomatic cables. What they found, once they cracked the cipher in the late 1940s, was not peace negotiations. It was something far more alarming.

The Soviet Union had been running an extensive espionage network inside the United States government for years. Dozens of agents. Multiple agencies. People at senior levels in the State Department, the Treasury, and the OSS, the wartime predecessor to the CIA. The cables named them, or rather, named their code names. The real identities had to be pieced together from context.

One cable, designated Venona 1822 and sent in March 1945, described a Soviet agent referred to by the code name ALES. The cable said ALES had been working for Soviet military intelligence since 1935. It said he was a high-ranking State Department official. It said he had attended the Yalta Conference, the same summit where FDR, Churchill, and Stalin had divided the postwar world. And it said that after Yalta, ALES had met with a Soviet intelligence officer in Moscow, where he was decorated for his service.

There were not many people who fit all of those descriptions. The Venona analysts, and later the FBI, concluded that ALES was almost certainly Alger Hiss.

Here is the part that makes your jaw drop: none of this was public knowledge at the time of the trial. The Venona program was so classified that J. Edgar Hoover would not even tell President Truman about it in full. The prosecutors who convicted Hiss in 1950 could not use the Venona intercepts as evidence because doing so would have revealed that the United States had broken Soviet codes. The Soviets would have immediately changed them, blinding American intelligence overnight. So the government stayed quiet, convicted Hiss on other evidence, and locked the Venona files away for another forty-five years.

The cables were not declassified until 1995 and 1996, released jointly by the CIA and the NSA. By then Alger Hiss was 91 years old.

The Pumpkin Papers: What the Headlines Left Out

When Whittaker Chambers led investigators to his Maryland farm in December 1948 and pulled five rolls of 35mm film from a hollowed-out pumpkin, it became one of the most dramatic moments in Cold War history. The image of Richard Nixon holding strips of microfilm up to the light is one of the iconic photographs of the era.

What the dramatic staging obscured was what was actually on the film.

When researchers finally pried the Pumpkin Papers loose from government custody in 1975, through a lawsuit under the Freedom of Information Act filed more than a quarter century after the trial, the contents turned out to be considerably less explosive than advertised.

One roll of film was completely blank. Overexposure had destroyed whatever images it might have contained.

Two more rolls contained photographs of Navy Department documents about life rafts, fire extinguishers, and other routine shipboard equipment. None of it had been classified. Any member of the public could have obtained it.

Only two of the five rolls showed anything that was actually classified at the time: photographs of State Department documents that had been entered into evidence at the trials.

None of this proved Hiss was innocent. The classified documents on those two rolls were real, and they represented a serious security breach. But the Pumpkin Papers had been presented to the public and the press as a devastating cache of spy secrets, and the reality was rather more complicated. Two rolls of classified documents, two rolls of publicly available naval trivia, and one roll of nothing.

Hiss's supporters pointed to this for years as evidence of how the case had been built on theater as much as substance. His detractors pointed out that the classified rolls were damning enough on their own and that the rest was irrelevant.

Both sides had a point. That is how it usually goes with Alger Hiss.

The Typewriter That May Not Have Been Real

Of everything in the Hiss case, the Woodstock typewriter is the detail that keeps pulling historians back.

The prosecution's physical case against Hiss rested almost entirely on 65 pages of retyped State Department documents that Chambers claimed Priscilla Hiss had copied on their family typewriter for transmission to the Soviets. FBI laboratory analysis concluded that the documents matched the typing characteristics of the Hiss family's Woodstock, serial number N230099.

The defense went looking for the typewriter to disprove this. They found it, discarded in a junk pile and apparently given away by the Hiss family years earlier, and brought it into court themselves, believing it would help them. It did not. The prosecution's experts testified that the machine in the courtroom matched the Baltimore documents perfectly, and that was effectively that.

After his conviction, Hiss's legal team began to reconsider.

They hired a man named Martin Tytell, a New York typewriter specialist who claimed he could duplicate any machine's typing characteristics. Tytell spent three years and his own money attempting to build a Woodstock that typed identically to the one in evidence. He told Hiss's lawyers he had succeeded. The theory that emerged was dismissed by the government as, in their words, a Grimm fairy tale with a Rube Goldberg twist.

Courts agreed. Every appeal Hiss filed was rejected.

But the typewriter question refused to die entirely. A researcher digging into FBI files years later found evidence suggesting the bureau had conducted its own investigation into the typewriter's serial number before the first trial and that the results of that investigation had raised questions internally that were never disclosed to the defense. What exactly those questions were, and whether they amounted to anything, remains disputed.

What is not disputed is that Hiss said two sentences after his conviction. The first was to thank the judge. The second was to say that one day, the world would learn how forgery by typewriter had been

committed.

He repeated some version of that claim for the remaining 46 years of his life.

The Russian Who Changed His Story

When the Soviet Union collapsed in 1991, Alger Hiss saw his opportunity.

He asked the new Russian government to examine the KGB archives for any record of his involvement with Soviet intelligence. His longtime lawyer and supporter, John Lowenthal, arranged for a respected Russian military historian named General Dmitri Volkogonov to conduct the search.

In late 1992, Volkogonov issued a letter. He stated that after a careful analysis of all available information, he could confirm that Alger Hiss had never been an agent of Soviet intelligence. Hiss's supporters celebrated. Headlines ran. At age 88, after more than four decades of fighting, it appeared Hiss might finally get the exoneration he had always sought.

It lasted about two weeks.

Historians and journalists began to scrutinize Volkogonov's methodology. They found that he had spent only two days examining files at the archive. He had not examined the records of the GRU, the Soviet military intelligence agency, at all. This mattered enormously because the entire prosecution case, and Chambers's own testimony, had always placed Hiss in the GRU network, not the KGB. Volkogonov had searched the wrong files.

When confronted with this, Volkogonov did not defend his conclusion. He told The New York Times that his earlier statement had been made too hastily and that he had not intended to exonerate Hiss. He said he relied on archivists acting under orders from the SVR, the KGB's successor organization, to select which files he would be allowed to see. The SVR, it turned out, had not shown him the GRU material at all.

Hiss's partial exoneration evaporated as quickly as it had appeared.

Three years later, the Venona cables were declassified. Senator Daniel Patrick Moynihan, who chaired the commission overseeing their release, said the cables left, in his judgment, no doubt as to the guilt of Alger Hiss.

Hiss was still alive. He was 91 years old. He said it was not enough.

What the Evidence Actually Shows

Here is where things stand, as honestly as they can be stated.

The case for guilt is substantial and has only grown stronger over time. The Venona intercepts describe an agent code-named ALES who matches Alger Hiss in nearly every particular: seniority, agency, presence at Yalta, and timeline of service to Soviet intelligence dating back to 1935. KGB archive materials accessed by researchers in the 1990s, while not a direct file on Hiss, contain corroborating references. Multiple Soviet defectors and former intelligence officers identified Hiss or described operations consistent with his involvement. The FBI's typewriter evidence, while contested, was accepted by two different juries and upheld by every court that reviewed it.

The case for doubt is narrower but not nothing. The Venona identification of ALES as Hiss rests on inference, not a document that names him directly. Volkogonov's clumsy search did not prove Hiss was innocent, but the fact that Russia has never released a direct file on Hiss from the GRU, despite decades of requests, means the most definitive evidence, if it exists, has never been seen. The typewriter story has enough loose threads that serious researchers still pull at them. Chambers, the prosecution's star witness, admitted under oath to having lied repeatedly under oath. That paradox has never been fully resolved.

What is not in dispute is that the Hiss case, whatever the ultimate truth of it, became something larger than any single man's guilt or innocence. It became a weapon. His conviction was the match that lit McCarthy's fire. Nixon rode it from a junior House seat to the White House. A decade of political persecution followed. Careers destroyed, reputations shredded, lives ruined, all built on the emotional energy of a single trial in New York.

Alger Hiss died in 1996 with his conviction intact, readmitted to the bar but never exonerated by the courts, maintaining his innocence to the end. The GRU files that would settle the matter conclusively, if they still exist and if they were ever opened, remain in Moscow.

They have not been opened.

This deeper dive was prepared exclusively for Echo & Chronicle subscribers using declassified government documents, the Venona transcripts released by the CIA and NSA, and the FBI case file available in full at echoandchronicle.today. The article that accompanies this piece, along with the original declassified FBI documents, can be found at:

echoandchronicle.today/articles/alger-hiss-may-31-1949